endeavour in Afghanistan.[84] Though Chidambaram was firm on using force to counter anti-India militants, the conciliatory initiative resonated with Manmohan Singh's regional strategy.[85] It contributed towards the UPA-II's vision of developing economic dependencies between India, Pakistan, and Afghanistan to reduce political turmoil in the region. Senior Indian military intelligence officers soon began to instruct their deputies in Afghanistan to build links with the Afghan Taliban.[86] While the precise nature of India's covert dealings with the Afghan Taliban remains unknown, there was a visible shift in how Indian government and business officials, who travelled extensively to Afghanistan, began viewing the Afghan Taliban. For a FICCI official, who knew the nitty-gritty of India's presence in Afghanistan, 'a true Taliban will be a true Afghan and a true Afghan will not let the country go back by destroying whatever it has built in the last decade ... But they [Afghan Taliban] are afraid of other kind of insurgencies from the neighbours [Pakistan]'.[87] T concurs that senior R&AW officers began offering inputs to the JIC from sources which they claimed were 'higher up in the [Afghan] Taliban hierarchy'.[88] Led by Menon, the conciliators steered India's Afghanistan policy after 2010.

On 29 March 2010, soon after Menon's appointment, the *Indian Express* broke a story that 'India shifts Afghan policy, ready to talk to Taliban'. At Menon's orders, India had opened channel with Hekmatyar, who was termed Pakistan's 'Frankenstein's Monster' by the Indian media in the 1990s, and even entertained feelers from the Quetta Shura, whose spokesperson Zabiullah Mujahid openly talked about reconciling with India:

> This fine-tuning of India's position on Afghanistan comes after exchange of views between top diplomats. After the February [2010] attack on Indians in Kabul, Vice-President Hamid Ansari, Pakistan-Afghanistan envoy Satinder Lambah, and former West Asia envoy Chinmaya Gharekhan wanted India to adopt a neutral position in Afghanistan. This essentially meant keeping out of [internal] Afghanistan politics but carrying on the development works in the war-torn republic[89]

Menon corroborated the report by the *Indian Express*.[90] The MEA had prepared a paper that advocated proactive measures to prevent Afghanistan slipping back into a spiral of violence similar to that in the 1990s. The *Indian Express* assessed that the sub-text of the paper was that 'Afghanistan will come under the total influence of Pakistan if New Delhi was to let matters go out of